## Guru Dutt

*(1925-1964)*

Gone too soon at age 39, his training as a dancer under Uday Shankar always seems a relevant fact: unerring timing and movement mark his lens-eye. His flair for lighting and framing were already evident in the two Bombay noir films he debuted with: *Baazi* (1951) and *Jaal* (1952). After a mid-'50s detour to romantic comedy (*Aar Paar*, *Mr. & Mrs. 55*), he set out to craft the classics—*Pyaasa* (1957), *Kaagaz ke Phool* (1959) and *Sahib Bibi aur Ghulam* (1962)—that burn still like ethereal candle-flames.



INDIA PICTURE



HEMANT PITHWA

## Hrishikesh Mukherjee

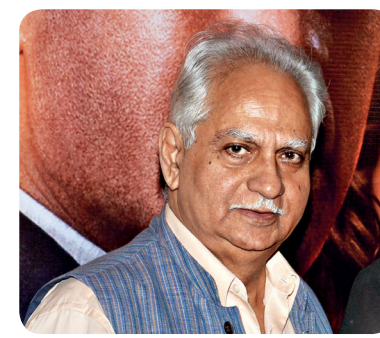
*(1922-2006)*

**A protégé of Bimal Roy, and already multi-gifted as assistant director, cameraman and editor, he reserved a special nook for himself amidst Bollywood's magnum opuses with a charming set of small, human, middle-of-the-road films. The colours ranged across very many microtones—from *Anari* (1959), to *Anuradha* (1960), *Anupama* (1966), *Satyakam* (1969), *Guddi*, *Anand* (both 1971), *Abhimaan* (1973), they all had nuanced, often near-literary portraitures and an unfailing yen for storytelling. And yet, many would remember him for his comedies *Chupke Chupke* (1975) and *Gol Maal* (1979).**

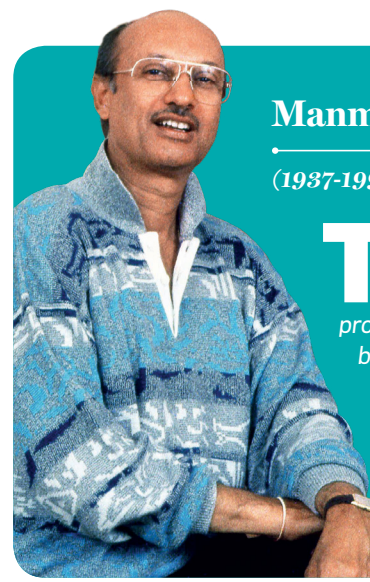
## Ramesh Sippy

*(1947-)*

**The wunderkind-son of producer G.P. Sippy originally had an army story in his mind before the Salim-Javed script morphed into what was to become cinema history. The dacoit-vs-village epic *Sholay* (1975)—Kurosawa's *Seven Samurai*, Anthony Quinn-starrer *Guns for San Sebastian* and other borrowings too numerous to count, all brought to boil into a flaming red curry—stands rock-firm as one of the most adored entertainers of all time. Sippy did give us *Shakti* (1982), *Saagar* (1985) and *Buniyaad* (1986-87), but that coal could burn so magnificently only once.**



MILIND SHELTE



## Manmohan Desai

*(1937-1994)*

*The Man of Miracles had once predicted, "You critics can laugh at me but one day you'll call me the Steven Spielberg of India." Well, 'Manji' was prone to exaggeration, but he could convince you to believe in the implausible. Would you believe now that he had commenced his innings with a serious B&W outing,* Chhalia *(1960), adapted from Dostoevsky's* White Nights*? For, his packed masala box will always be known for that ultimate condiment:* Amar Akbar Anthony *(1977).*

NAMAS BHOJANI